

- RAG Learning

Eduqas GCSE Geography B (C112QS) — Theme 2: Changing Environments

2.2 Shaping the Landscape — Rivers and River Management

1. The River as a System

A river and its drainage basin function as an **open system** — water, sediment, and energy enter, are processed, and leave. Understanding this systems framework underpins all river processes and landforms.

Key Drainage Basin Terms

Drainage basin: The area of land drained by a river and its tributaries. Also called a **catchment area**. It is bounded by a **watershed** (the ridge of high land separating one drainage basin from another).

Watershed: The boundary (usually a ridge) separating one drainage basin from another. Precipitation falling on one side flows into a different river system.

Tributary: A smaller stream or river that joins a larger one.

Confluence: The point where two rivers or streams join.

Source: The origin (usually highest point) of a river, often a spring, bog, or lake.

Mouth: Where the river meets the sea or a lake. Discharge is greatest here.

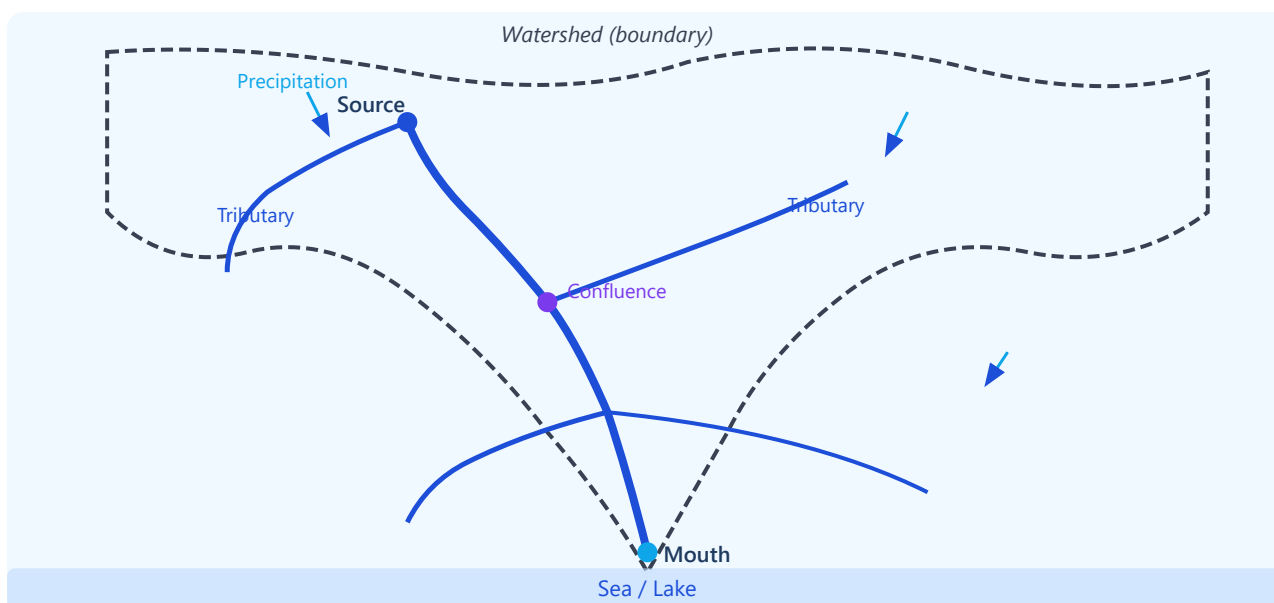


Fig 2.1 — A drainage basin showing watershed, source, tributaries, confluence, and mouth

Inputs, Throughputs, and Outputs

Component	Description
Input	Precipitation (rain, snow, sleet) — enters the drainage basin as water
Infiltration	Water soaking into the soil; rate depends on soil type, saturation, vegetation
Surface runoff (overland flow)	Water flowing over land surface when infiltration capacity is exceeded; fast — reaches river quickly
Throughflow	Water moving through the soil layer, parallel to the slope; moderate speed
Groundwater flow	Slow movement of water through permeable rock; sustains rivers during dry spells (base flow)
Output: River discharge	Volume of water passing a point per second (cumecs, m ³ /s); measured at gauging stations
Output: Evapotranspiration	Water lost to atmosphere through evaporation + plant transpiration; higher in summer

2. River Processes

Erosion

Hydraulic Action: The force of flowing water pushing into cracks and joints in the river bed and banks. The pressure compresses air, weakens rock, and can dislodge large blocks. Most effective during floods.

Abrasion (Corrasion): The load carried by the river (pebbles, sand) acts like sandpaper, scraping and grinding the bed and banks. Responsible for vertical and lateral erosion; creates smooth, polished channels.

Attrition: Particles of load collide with each other, becoming progressively smaller, rounder, and smoother as they travel downstream. Explains why large angular boulders near the source become small, round pebbles near the mouth.

Corrosion (Solution): Slightly acidic river water chemically dissolves soluble minerals (e.g., calcium carbonate in limestone). The dissolved material is carried in solution. Example: limestone karst landscapes.

Rivers also erode in different directions: **vertical erosion** (downward, deepening the channel — dominant in upper course) and **lateral erosion** (sideways, widening the channel — dominant in middle and lower course).

Transportation

Process	Sediment type	Description
Traction	Boulders, cobbles	Largest material rolled along the river bed by the current
Saltation	Pebbles, coarse sand	Bounced along the bed in a series of hops

Suspension	Fine silt, clay	Carried within the water column; gives rivers brown colour after heavy rain
Solution	Dissolved minerals	Carried invisibly in the water; always in transport regardless of velocity

Deposition

Deposition occurs when a river loses **energy** (velocity decreases) and can no longer carry its load. This happens when: gradient decreases (entering a flood plain), discharge falls (drought, abstraction), the river meets the sea (loses velocity), or on the inside of meander bends (reduced velocity). The largest/heaviest material is deposited first.

The Hjulström Curve

The Hjulström curve shows the relationship between water velocity and sediment behaviour (erosion, transport, deposition):

- **Erosion velocity** — the minimum velocity needed to pick up (entrain) sediment of a given size. Coarser sediment requires more velocity; but importantly, fine clays also need relatively high velocity because they are cohesive (stuck together).
- **Settling/deposition velocity** — the velocity at which a particle is deposited. This is always lower than erosion velocity.
- **Key point:** Once in transport, fine silt/clay can be carried at very low velocities. Large boulders require very high velocities to be entrained, but once moving, they are deposited as soon as velocity drops below transport velocity.

Exam Tip: The Hjulström curve is tricky — remember that fine clays require a surprisingly high velocity to erode (because they are cohesive), but once in suspension they stay in transport at very low velocities. For boulders: high velocity to move, and deposited rapidly when velocity drops.

3. The Long Profile and Changes Downstream

The **long profile** of a river is a cross-section from source to mouth, showing how gradient changes. Near the source, the gradient is steep; by the lower course, it has almost flattened out, forming a smooth

concave curve called the **graded profile**.

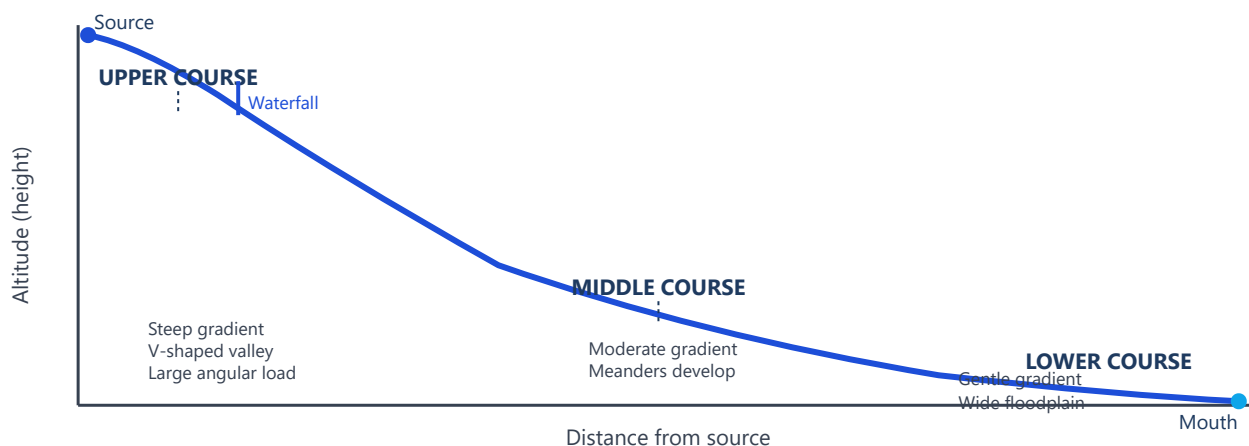


Fig 2.2 — River long profile (concave shape) showing upper, middle, and lower course characteristics

Variable	Upper Course	Middle Course	Lower Course
Gradient	Steep	Moderate	Gentle/flat
Velocity	Low (high friction)	Increasing	Fastest overall
Discharge	Lowest	Increasing (tributaries)	Highest
Channel width	Narrow	Wider	Widest
Channel depth	Shallow	Deeper	Deepest
Load size	Large, angular boulders	Pebbles, gravels	Fine sand, silt
Dominant erosion	Vertical (deepening)	Lateral (widening)	Lateral (very wide)
Valley shape	V-shaped, narrow	Wider, flatter floor	Broad, flat floodplain

4. Upper Course Landforms

V-Shaped Valleys and Interlocking Spurs

In the upper course, the river mainly erodes **vertically**, cutting downward into the bedrock. The valley sides are steep because:

- Rainwater washes material off steep valley sides (mass movement and surface wash)
- The valley floor is narrow — little lateral erosion
- Weathering (freeze-thaw) loosens material on the valley sides which falls into the river

The resulting valley has a classic **V-shape**. The river winds around resistant spurs of rock, which jut into the valley from alternate sides — these are called **interlocking spurs**.

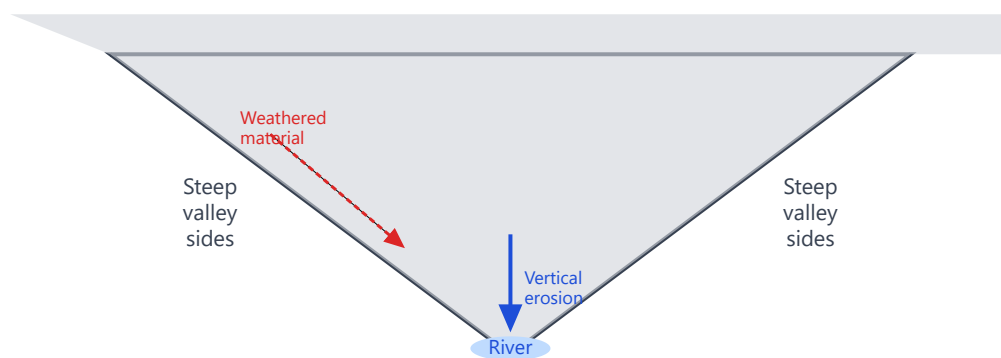


Fig 2.3 — V-shaped valley cross-section: vertical erosion by river + weathering of valley sides

Waterfalls and Gorges

Waterfalls form where a river crosses a band of **resistant rock** overlying softer rock. The sequence of formation:

1. The river flows over the hard rock cap; beneath, softer rock erodes faster by hydraulic action and abrasion
2. A **plunge pool** forms at the base where the falling water churns the rock
3. The hard cap rock is undercut and becomes unsupported; eventually it collapses
4. The waterfall retreats upstream, leaving a steep-sided **gorge** in its wake

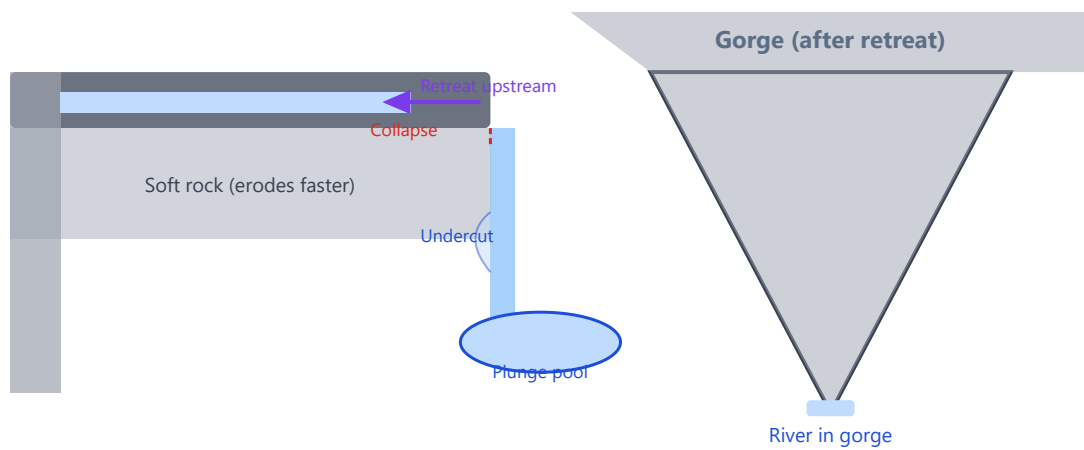


Fig 2.4 — Waterfall formation and retreat, leaving a gorge. Example: High Force, River Tees, County Durham

Example: High Force, River Tees — often described as England's largest waterfall by volume. Hard Whin Sill dolerite overlies softer Carboniferous limestone; the waterfall has retreated ~700 m to form a gorge.

5. Middle Course Landforms

Meanders

As the river enters the middle course, the valley widens and the river begins to swing in wide bends called **meanders**. They develop because of differences in velocity across the channel:

- On the **outer bend** — faster flow (greater centrifugal force), erosion by abrasion and hydraulic action creates a steep **river cliff** (cut bank)
- On the **inner bend** — slower flow, deposition builds up a **slip-off slope** (point bar) of sand and gravel
- A secondary **helical (corkscrew) flow** called **helicoidal flow** moves water and sediment from the outer bank to the inner bend, enhancing the asymmetric shape

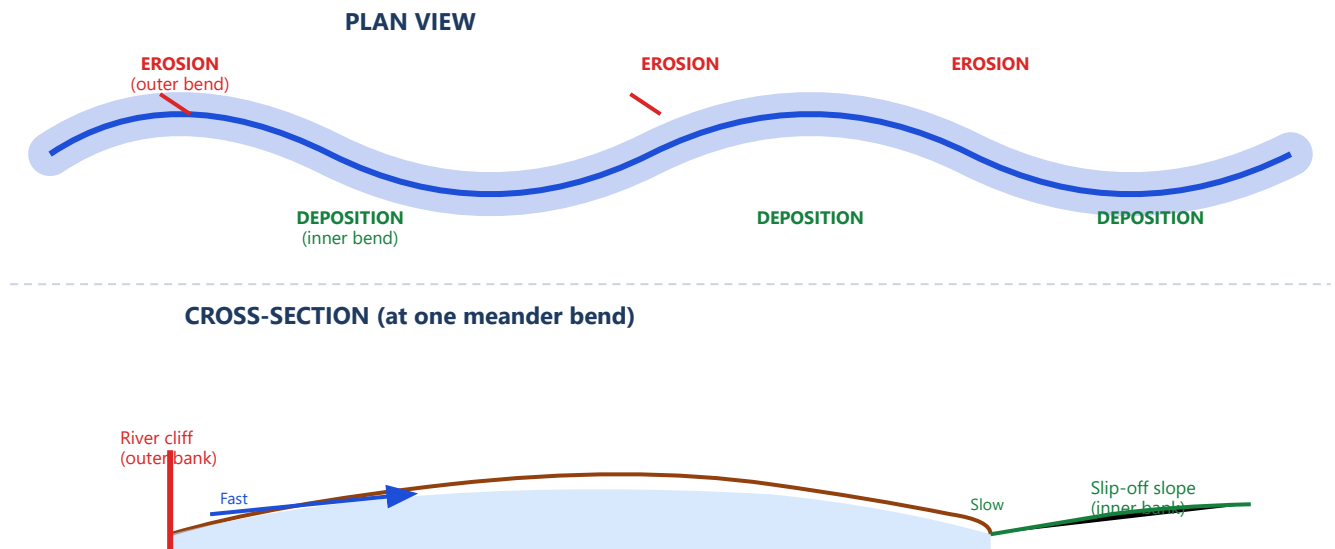


Fig 2.5 — Meander plan view (top) and cross-section (bottom) showing river cliff on outer bank and slip-off slope on inner bank

6. Lower Course Landforms

Ox-bow Lakes

Ox-bow lakes form from meanders through a 4-stage process:

1. The meander bends become increasingly tight (tortuous) as erosion continues on outer bends
2. During a flood, the river cuts through the narrow neck of land between two adjacent meander bends (the shortest route)
3. The river straightens, depositing sediment (alluvium) at both ends of the old meander loop
4. The abandoned meander bend is cut off, forming a horseshoe-shaped **ox-bow lake**
5. Over time, the ox-bow dries up, leaving a curved **meander scar**

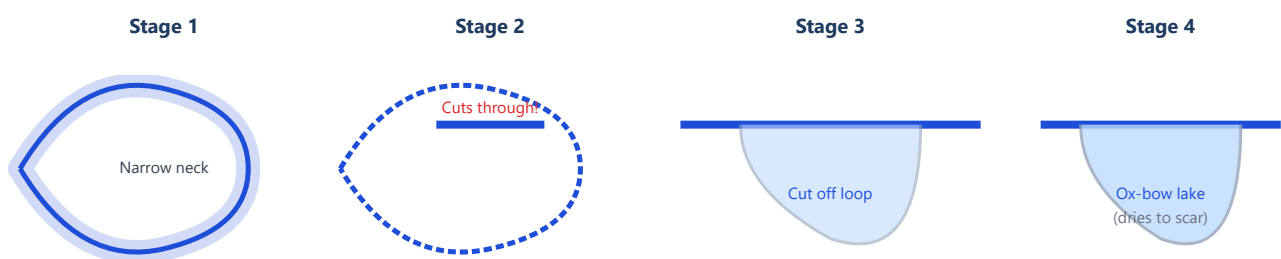


Fig 2.6 — Four-stage formation of an ox-bow lake from a meander

Flood Plains

A **flood plain** is the flat, low-lying area either side of the river channel, formed by repeated flooding and lateral erosion. During floods, the river overtops its banks and velocity drops immediately — sediment (alluvium) is deposited across the flood plain, gradually building it up. Flood plains are the most fertile agricultural land due to mineral-rich alluvium.

Levées

Natural embankments alongside river channels. During floods, coarsest sediment is deposited immediately adjacent to the channel (as velocity falls sharply at the bank). Over many flood events, these deposits build up to form **levées**. They may raise the channel above the level of the surrounding flood plain. When levées breach (break), flooding can be catastrophic (e.g., Yellow River, China; Mississippi, USA).

Deltas

Deltas form at river mouths where sediment load is deposited faster than it can be removed by tidal currents or waves. The river splits into distributaries. Two main types:

- **Arcuate delta** — fan-shaped, smoothed by wave action. Example: Nile Delta, Egypt
- **Bird's foot delta** — long, finger-like distributaries extending into calm water. Example: Mississippi Delta, USA

7. Storm Hydrographs

A **storm hydrograph** shows how river discharge responds to a rainfall event over time. It is a key tool for flood prediction and management.

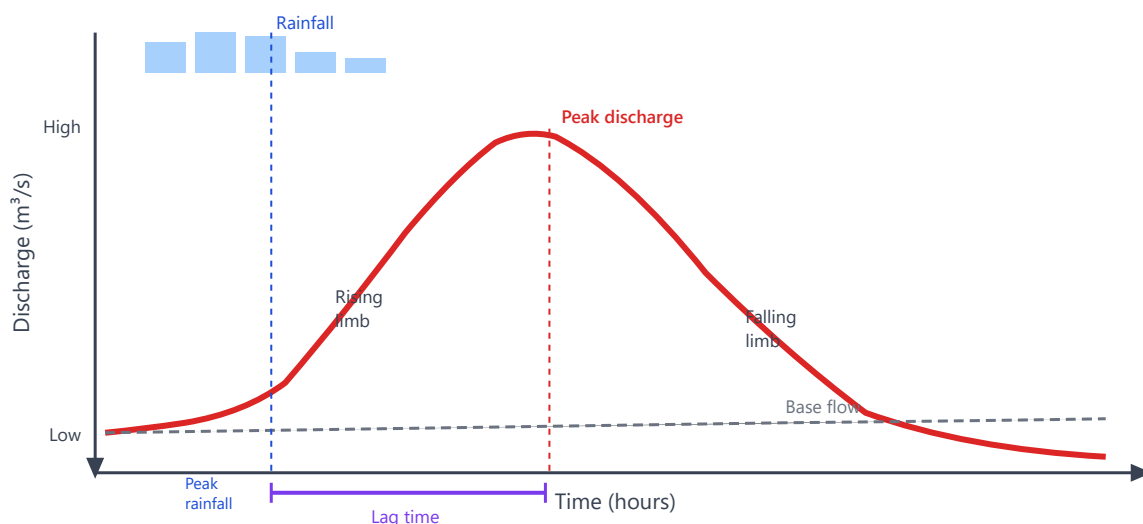


Fig 2.7 — A storm hydrograph showing key components

Key Components

Term	Definition
Rising limb	The rising section of the graph as discharge increases after rainfall
Peak discharge	The maximum discharge reached after a storm event (m^3/s)
Lag time	The time delay between peak rainfall and peak discharge; shorter = flashier = more flood risk
Falling limb (recession limb)	The gradual decrease in discharge as water drains away
Base flow	The background level of discharge sustained by groundwater between storms

Factors Affecting Hydrograph Shape

Factor	Flashy hydrograph (short lag, high peak)	Subdued hydrograph (long lag, low peak)
Land use	Urban areas (impermeable tarmac, drains)	Forest/pasture (infiltration, interception)
Rock type	Impermeable rock (granite, clay)	Permeable rock (chalk, sandstone)
Rainfall intensity	Heavy, intense, short storm	Light, prolonged drizzle
Vegetation	Bare soil, arable fields, deforested	Dense woodland, grassland
Slope angle	Steep slopes — rapid runoff	Gentle slopes — slow runoff
Antecedent soil moisture	Already saturated soil — rapid runoff	Dry soil — high infiltration capacity

Exam Tip: When describing a hydrograph, always quote figures: "peak discharge of $X \text{ m}^3/\text{s}$ ", "lag time of Y hours". When explaining hydrograph shape, give reasons linked to the specific drainage basin characteristics — e.g., "the short lag time of 2 hours suggests an urbanised catchment with impermeable surfaces and efficient drainage systems."

8. Causes and Effects of Flooding

Physical Causes

- **Prolonged rainfall** — saturates soil, reducing infiltration; surface runoff increases rapidly
- **Heavy, intense storms** — rainfall exceeds infiltration capacity immediately
- **Snowmelt** — rapid melting in spring (especially when combined with rain) releases large volumes of water
- **Impermeable rock** (granite, clay) — little water infiltrates, most runs off
- **Steep slopes** — water reaches the river channel quickly
- **Low vegetation cover** — less interception and transpiration

Human Causes

- **Urbanisation** — tarmac, concrete, and rooftops are impermeable; drains deliver water rapidly to rivers, reducing lag time and increasing peak discharge
- **Deforestation** — trees intercept rainfall and roots absorb water; removing trees increases runoff and reduces evapotranspiration
- **Floodplain development** — building on flood plains removes natural storage capacity and increases flood risk downstream
- **Overgrazing and compaction** — compacted soils reduce infiltration rates
- **Climate change** — more intense rainfall events; changing precipitation patterns

Case Study: Boscastle Flash Flood, Cornwall, August 2004

Event: On 16 August 2004, exceptionally heavy convective rainfall (about 185 mm on high ground in around 5 hours, with 89 mm in one hour at Boscastle — often quoted as a 1-in-400-year event) fell over the small drainage basin of the River Valency and River Jordan above Boscastle village.

Physical causes:

- Intense, localised convectional rainfall triggered by a stationary low-pressure system on a hot August day
- Steep valley sides and impermeable Devonian slate bedrock — rapid surface runoff
- Small, steep drainage basin with short lag time
- Soils already saturated from previous days of rain

Effects:

- Flood peak estimated at 140 m³/s (normally ~1 m³/s) — a 140-fold increase
- Floodwaters reached 3 m deep in the narrow village street
- About 80 cars, plus caravans and boats, swept out to sea; four bridges destroyed; B3263 road badly damaged
- Around 60 properties flooded in Boscastle and about 100 homes and businesses damaged or destroyed across the area
- No deaths (thanks to emergency services); about 150 people rescued by seven helicopters

Management responses:

- The valley was redeveloped with a flood alleviation scheme: river channel widened and deepened; culverts removed; car park relocated to higher ground
- New footbridge designed to allow debris to pass through
- Costs: damage estimated at tens of millions of pounds; the Environment Agency's flood defence scheme (completed 2008) cost around £4.6 million

9. River Management Strategies

Hard Engineering

Strategy	Description	Advantages	Disadvantages
Dams and reservoirs	Large concrete structures built across	Highly effective flood control; HEP	Extremely expensive; displaces communities; traps sediment

	river valleys; reservoir stores water, controlling release	generation; water supply; recreation	(delta starvation downstream); dam failure catastrophic; destroys habitats
Channel straightening (channelisation)	Meanders cut off to create a straight channel; may line channel with concrete	Water removed faster; reduces local flooding	Increases flooding downstream (water arrives faster); destroys habitat; unnatural; channel can re-meander
Embankments (artificial levées)	Raised earthen or concrete banks along river channel to contain flood water	Relatively cheap; can raise height over time; allows floodplain use	If breached, flooding is catastrophic; increases flood risk downstream; regular maintenance needed
Flood relief channels	Parallel channels dug to carry overflow when main channel is in flood	Effective; can be designed to specific discharge; reduces pressure on main channel	Land take; expensive to construct; only effective if correctly sized for design flood

Soft Engineering

Strategy	Description	Advantages	Disadvantages
Afforestation	Planting trees in the drainage basin to increase interception and infiltration	Sustainable; cheap; improves biodiversity; carbon sequestration; reduces runoff long-term	Takes decades to be effective; may reduce agricultural productivity of upland areas
Floodplain zoning	Planning regulations prevent development on flood-risk areas; land left as parks, recreation	Prevents building in flood zones; relatively cheap; maintains natural floodplain function	Restricts development in areas where land is scarce; planning enforcement required; does not reduce existing flood risk
Washlands / water	Designated areas of floodplain deliberately	Free; natural; reduces flood peak; maintains	Takes agricultural land out of production; only useful for

meadows	allowed to flood to temporarily store excess water	biodiversity; no maintenance needed	moderate floods; landowner compensation needed
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Exam Tip: For "evaluate" questions on river management, always consider: **effectiveness, cost, sustainability, impact on people and environment, and downstream effects**. Hard engineering tends to be effective short-term but can transfer the problem downstream. Soft engineering is more sustainable but may take time to work and requires large areas of land.

10. Case Study — Bangladesh Flooding

Case Study: Bangladesh — Causes, Effects, and Management of Flooding

Background: Bangladesh is one of the world's most flood-prone countries. Around **80% of the country is a flood plain** (the combined Ganges-Brahmaputra-Meghna delta). Each year, 20–30% of the country floods during the monsoon season (June–September); in severe years (e.g., 1998, 2017), 60–70% is submerged.

Physical causes:

- Three major rivers (Ganges, Brahmaputra, Meghna) converge in Bangladesh, bringing meltwater from Himalayan glaciers and monsoon rain from across South Asia
- **Snowmelt** in spring adds to river discharge before the monsoon even begins
- **Monsoon rainfall** — Bangladesh receives around 2,000–2,500 mm/year on average (over 4,000 mm in the north-east), mostly June–September; very intense daily totals possible
- Flat, low-lying land — much of Bangladesh is <1 m above sea level; water cannot drain away
- Cyclones (e.g., Cyclone Sidr 2007) bring storm surges and coastal flooding from the Bay of Bengal

Human causes:

- **Deforestation** in Nepal and the Himalayas has increased surface runoff and sediment load into rivers
- Population growth and urbanisation on floodplain land increases flood vulnerability
- **Climate change** — rising sea levels (Bangladesh is predicted to lose 17% of land area by 2050 with a 1 m rise) and more intense storms

- Upstream water management (dams in India) can cause unpredictable water releases

Effects of flooding (e.g., 1998 floods — the most severe of the 20th century):

- 66% of Bangladesh submerged for 2–3 months
- 30 million people made homeless
- 1,100 deaths from drowning, disease (cholera, typhoid), and snake bites
- 700,000 ha of cropland destroyed — food security crisis; rice prices rose by 30%
- ~\$1 billion damage to infrastructure (roads, bridges, schools, clinics)
- Dhaka (capital city) partly submerged; factories closed, economic losses severe

Positive effects:

- Annual flooding deposits rich alluvium, making Bangladesh's soils extremely fertile — foundation of its rice agriculture
- Recharges groundwater aquifers

Management responses:

- **Flood Action Plan (FAP)** — funded by World Bank; involves building 7,000 km of embankments along rivers. Controversial: embankments can fail catastrophically; traps water inside; disrupts fishing; does not address causes
- **Flood Forecasting and Warning Centre (FFWC)** — river gauge monitoring and satellite data used to give 72-hour flood forecasts; allows evacuation of vulnerable areas
- **Flood shelters** — raised concrete cyclone shelters provide refuge for 1–2 million people during flooding; particularly important in coastal zones
- **BRAC (NGO)** — community-level flood preparedness: waterproof storage of food, seeds, and documents; floating gardens (baira) for food production during floods
- **Flood-resistant housing** — houses built on raised platforms (plinth) using earth mounds; bamboo and concrete designs that withstand moderate flooding

Evaluation: Hard engineering (embankments) has had mixed results — protecting some areas while increasing risk in others. Community-based approaches (early warning, shelters, flood-resistant crops) are increasingly recognised as more sustainable for a country that cannot afford to prevent

flooding and must learn to live with it. Climate change and sea-level rise make long-term management increasingly difficult.

Exam Tip: Bangladesh is a superb multi-mark case study because it links physical geography (rivers, monsoon, delta), human geography (poverty, population), and global issues (climate change, sea-level rise, deforestation). Always include statistics: "66% of Bangladesh flooded in 1998", "30 million homeless", "80% of land is floodplain". Generic answers without data score in band 1 only.

11. Estuaries

Eduqas names the **estuary** among the landforms you must cover, and it is the one most often left out. An estuary is the tidal mouth of a river, where fresh water meets salt water and the channel widens into a funnel shape.

How an Estuary Forms and Functions

- **Setting:** Most UK estuaries are drowned river valleys — the sea flooded the lower course after the last glacial period as ice melted and sea level rose. That is why they are wide relative to the river that flows through them.
- **Deposition:** Twice a day the tide slows and then reverses the river's flow. At high and low slack water, velocity falls to almost nothing and the river drops its load.
- **Flocculation:** Fine clay particles carry a slight electrical charge. When fresh water meets salt water, dissolved salts neutralise that charge, so the particles clump together and become heavy enough to settle. This is why estuaries accumulate mud rather than sand, and why they are so much more effective sediment traps than the river upstream.
- **Resulting landforms:** Extensive **mudflats** exposed at low tide, colonised at their upper levels by salt-tolerant plants to form **salt marsh**, and cut by branching **tidal creeks** that drain the marsh surface.

Why Estuaries Matter

Value	Detail
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Ecological	Mudflats are extremely productive in invertebrates, supporting internationally important populations of wading birds and wildfowl. Many UK estuaries hold the highest levels of conservation designation
Flood defence	Salt marsh dissipates wave energy before it reaches the sea wall behind, reducing the height and cost of the defence needed. This is the argument behind managed realignment schemes such as Medmerry
Economic	Deep-water access made estuaries the natural sites for ports and industry — the Thames, Mersey, Humber, Severn and Milford Haven
Water quality	Salt marsh and mudflat filter nutrients and sediment from river water before it reaches the open sea

Exam Tip — Coastal Squeeze: Estuaries link this topic to 2.1. Where a hard sea wall is fixed in place and sea level rises, the salt marsh in front of it is progressively drowned and cannot migrate landward — coastal squeeze. The defence then loses the natural buffer that was protecting it, so it has to be raised, which squeezes the marsh further. Being able to explain that feedback is a strong way into a high-mark answer on either river or coastal management.

12. Why River Management Is Controversial

The final strand of this key idea asks why drainage basin management divides opinion, and what happens to places *downstream* of a management decision. The underlying problem is the same as on the coast: a drainage basin is one connected system, but the people in it are not one group.

The Management Options in Dispute

Option	What it does	Why it is disputed
Dredging	Removing accumulated sediment to deepen a channel so it carries more water	Popular with residents and farmers because the effect is visible and immediate. Hydrologists point out that it moves water downstream faster, increasing flood risk there, that it has to be repeated continually, and that it

		damages river habitat. The Somerset Levels floods of 2013–14 turned this into a national argument
Channel straightening and embankments	Shortening and confining the channel so water leaves the reach quickly	Protects the reach that is engineered while raising the flood peak downstream. Also disconnects the river from its floodplain, removing natural storage
Dams and reservoirs	Storing water to control discharge and supply water or power	Land and settlements are lost upstream; sediment is trapped so the channel downstream erodes; water rights become contested
Afforestation	Planting trees in the upper catchment to intercept rainfall, increase infiltration and slow runoff	Cheap, sustainable and adds habitat, but takes decades to work and removes land from farming — so the cost falls on upland farmers while the benefit goes to downstream towns
Managed flooding	Deliberately allowing washlands or restored floodplain to flood, storing water where it does least harm	Works with natural processes and is often the cheapest option, but requires someone's land to be flooded on purpose — usually a farmer's, for the benefit of a town
Land use zoning	Planning policy that restricts development on the floodplain and directs it to lower-risk land	The cheapest measure of all and the most effective over time, but it reduces the development value of floodplain land and is fiercely resisted where housing is in short supply

Stakeholders and Their Values

Stakeholder	What they want	Why they clash with others
Floodplain residents	Immediate, visible protection for their homes	Favour dredging and hard engineering, which shift risk downstream
Farmers (lowland)	Drained, workable land and compensation if it is flooded	Oppose managed flooding and washland creation on their fields

Farmers and landowners (upland)	Productive grazing and forestry income	Resist afforestation and re-wetting schemes that reduce their usable land for downstream benefit
Environment Agency / Natural Resources Wales	Whole-catchment risk reduction at best value, plus habitat obligations	Favour natural flood management and land use zoning, which look like inaction to residents who want work done now
Local councils and developers	Housing land and council tax revenue	Press for floodplain development that increases runoff and puts new residents at risk
Water companies	Secure, cheap supply	Support abstraction and reservoirs that reduce flows for other users
Downstream communities	Not to receive someone else's water faster	Have no say in decisions made upstream in a different local authority area
Conservation groups	River habitat, fish passage, floodplain wetland	Oppose dredging, straightening and dams

The Downstream Problem

Almost every hard-engineering decision exports risk. Straightening, embanking or dredging a reach means the same volume of water arrives downstream sooner and in a sharper peak — a shorter lag time and a higher peak discharge on the hydrograph. Because river catchments cross local authority boundaries, the people who receive that water usually had no part in the decision. This is the strongest argument for **catchment-scale** management, in which the whole basin is planned together and upstream land is paid to store water for downstream benefit, rather than each town defending itself against its neighbours.

Exam Tip — Answering "Why is it controversial?": Do not just list who objects. Explain the structure of the disagreement: the costs and benefits of a scheme fall on *different people in different places*, and often at different times. Upland farmers bear the cost of afforestation that benefits a town twenty miles away in thirty years' time. Once you say that, everything else in the answer follows.